Data Center News

Think Tank Pennsylvania

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Springdale hearing: a crowd, a chorus, and 124 diesel generators

More than 40 speakers, most opposed, packed a county public hearing October 28 in Springdale over Dynamo DC's plan to turn the old coal plant into a data center campus. The fight centers on 124 diesel backup generators and their monthly testing. A backup generator is an engine that makes electricity when the grid fails; the borough limits testing to normal business hours. Residents worried about noise, air pollution, and cancer-causing emissions. Building-trades speakers who want the construction jobs were drowned out by jeers. Written comments stay open through November 30, and the county must decide by January 26, 2027.

https://www.publicsource.org/springdale-data-center-in-person-hearing (Pittsburgh Public Source)

PJM asks feds to make data centers pay for emergency power

On October 29, PJM Interconnection — the company that runs the power grid for Pennsylvania and 12 other states — asked federal regulators to approve an amended emergency plan. The plan would buy about 6,800 megawatts of backup power capacity and charge the cost to the large new electric loads driving the shortage, mainly data centers, rather than to households. One megawatt powers roughly 750 homes, so 6,800 megawatts is enough for about five million homes. The bid window runs March 1–28, 2027, with results due May 10. Note: this comes from PJM's own news outlet, so it tells PJM's side of the story.

https://insidelines.pjm.com/pjm-files-amended-reliability-backstop-proposal/ (PJM Inside Lines)

What data centers owe Western PA after Election Day

On the eve of today's election, 90.5 WESA traces how data centers became voters' top issue in Western Pennsylvania. Utility bills top the list of worries, and "No Data Center" signs dot South Strabane. Polls show more than three in four Pennsylvanians would not want a data center nearby. The piece centers on the 46th state Senate district: incumbent Camera Bartolotta defends her faster-permitting bill, SB 991, as a way to reclaim old industrial sites, while independent Jodi Borello wants a state moratorium. State Senator Katie Muth says voters have already subsidized data-center infrastructure through rate increases for five-plus years.

https://www.wesanews.org/politics-government/2026-10-29/pennsylvania-data-centers-voting-election (90.5 WESA)

10 Southwestern PA races, and where candidates stand on data centers

This voter guide covers ten Southwestern Pennsylvania races and where the candidates stand on electric bills, moratoriums, and ending the 2021 state sales-tax break for data centers. It walks through Senator Bartolotta's SB 991, a House bill proposing a 180-day development pause, and Representative Rob Matzie's push to end the tax exemption. More than 60 percent of voters dislike leaders who back nearby data centers, one poll found. Caution: with today's vote, the guide is already dating; several candidates did not respond.

https://technical.ly/civics/can-pa-lawmakers-control-the-data-center-boom/ (Technical.ly)

ONE TO WATCH

Patrick Boyle's 31-minute YouTube video "Elon Musk's Power Plant on Wheels" is a superb discussion of the issues and risks, with a national focus. Boyle reviews the three main public complaints and concludes: water concerns are largely overblown, low-frequency noise is a real problem, and electricity bills are rising. He then follows the money — debt backed by depreciating chips, risk landing in pension funds and annuities — and draws his own parallel between AI-infrastructure financing and the railroad bubble that collapsed in the Panic of 1873.
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NyOeLB0WVNE (YouTube)

 David L. Passmore, https://davidpassmore.net  Kaz, David's AI Agent from Muse